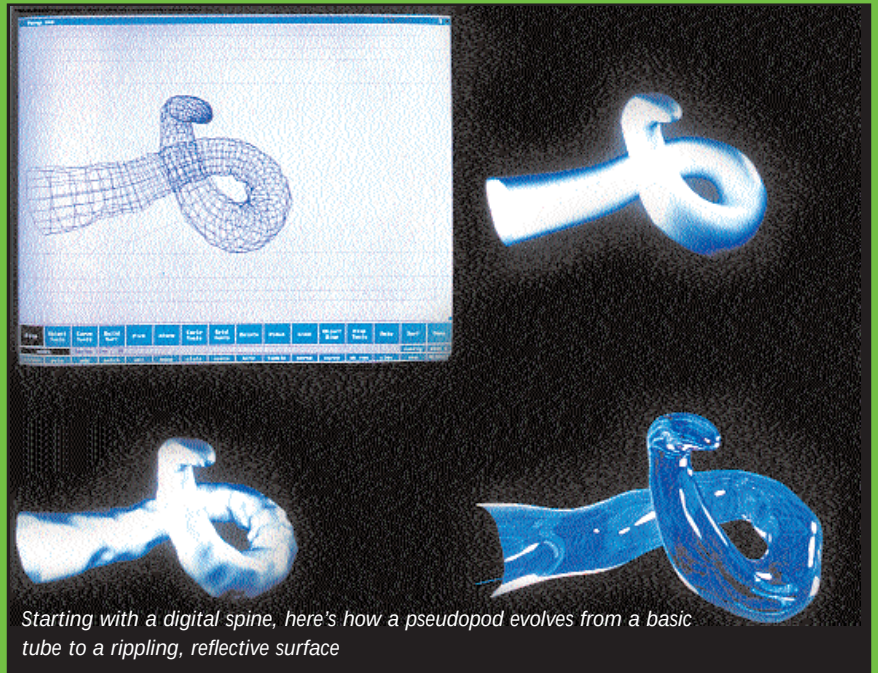


Bringing a 3D Model to Life

Making objects look real involves a deep understanding of shapes, surface textures, lighting, perspective, depth of field and anti-aliasing.

A human body may require thousands of shapes to be put together into a structure called a wireframe. The wireframe needs to be given a surface—a surface has colour and texture and reflects light. The computer should be able to choose from millions of different colours for the pixels making up an image. Variety in texture comes both from mathematical models for surfaces ranging from frog skin to gelatine and stored texture maps that are applied to surfaces. Adding a surface to the wireframe begins to change the image from something obviously mathematical to a recognisable picture.



This is where Apple has introduced the Final Cut Express (Rs 15,000 approx). It provides professional-level editing, compositing and real-time effects for full-featured DV editing. You can choose from hundreds of transitions, filters and effects, including the bundled library of digital video effects from CGM. You can also preview effects in real time without rendering. It also lets you mix up to 99 tracks of audio (eight in real time) at the subframe level.

Windows Movie Maker 2 makes home movies fun and easy, letting you create, edit and share your home movies right on your computer with a few simple drag-and-drop

moves. Add special effects, music and narration. Then share your movie via the Web, e-mail or CD. The Movie Maker, which comes with built-in support for Windows Media Video 9 compression, is a free product of the XP license and can automatically grab video from a camcorder, edit and analyse clips and create a short home movie, complete with music and credit. Movie Maker 2, which supports high-speed FireWire connections, also comes with a new feature called AutoMovie which promises to make the movie-making process a 5-minute job. The software includes nearly 30 video effects to jazz up home movies,

and disk space by capturing DVD-ready MPEG video straight from your camcorder or other device. Automatically split captured video scenes into separate easy-to-manage files. Scan your DV/D8 tape and select the parts you want. Then batch capture the clips with a click of the mouse.

The package includes over 100 Hollywood-style transitions, and 30 customisable filters for touching-up video and adding creative effects. You can animate text along motion paths, add voice narration, plus create soundtracks from favourite music CDs and MP3 files. You can also preview editing changes in real-time, arrange clips and add transitions with drag-and-drop ease using storyboard layout and edit audio, video and titles with frame-level accuracy in the Timeline mode.

To roll it all up

A director can now change lighting and weather conditions, or remove and add objects, and enter into a realm of digital potentialities that have profound effects on the entire mode of production. And it's only a matter of time before computer-generated virtual actors called synthesians or vactors get the creamy roles. But digital effects are no substitute for human emotions or a good storyline for that matter. So what are you waiting for? Get a good script and get cracking on your movie. 

LESLIE D'MONTE



Video editing with Final Cut Pro

video transitions to set scene changes with creative fades, wipes and other effects commonly used on television shows. It is built with more than 40 titles and credits.

Ulead Video studio 6 lets you transfer video from DV/D8/Hi8 camcorders, VCRs, PC cameras and TV tuner cards and comes for less than Rs 5,000. Save time